

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 1 Assignment — From Tester to QA Leader

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

You have just been appointed to lead QA at Northstar Digital, a Series B personal-finance company of around 120 people with a ~55-strong engineering org. You have inherited six QA engineers — including Sofia, the excellent exploratory tester who has been the informal lead, and Dan, who is quietly burning out on a flaky Selenium suite. Priya, the VP Engineering, is pragmatic and time-poor, and wants to see that you can size up the situation before you start changing things.

What you'll demonstrate

- Move from doing the testing to leading the function
- Structure a deliberate listening-and-learning period rather than reacting
- Identify quick wins, real risks and the people relationships that matter
- Frame early observations in the language of risk and delivery, not test-case counts

What to submit

- A First 30-Day QA Leadership Assessment (2–4 pages)
- A stakeholder and team map naming who you will meet and what you need from each
- A prioritised list of early observations, quick wins and things you will deliberately not touch yet

Step-by-step

1. Complete the QA Leader — First 30 Days Checklist against what you already know about Northstar
2. Plan your first conversations with Priya, Tom, Sofia, Dan and Marcus, noting the question you most need each to answer
3. Capture your current-state observations across people, process, tooling and metrics — as hypotheses to test, not conclusions
4. Choose two or three credible quick wins and state why each builds trust without destabilising delivery

5. Write the assessment: what you have learned, what you will investigate next, and what you will explicitly leave alone for now

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX, 2–4 pages, structured for a busy VP Engineering to read in one sitting.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- A listening-first posture rather than day-one restructuring
- Observations framed as risk and delivery impact, not personal criticism of the inherited team
- Realistic quick wins that earn trust without overreaching
- Evidence you understand the people, especially Sofia's wariness after last year's failed automation push
- Clear, senior writing pitched at an executive reader

Templates & resources to use

- QA Leader — First 30 Days Checklist — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Your first month is bought credibility, not spent authority. Diagnose in the open, commit to little, and let one well-chosen quick win speak louder than a reorganisation you cannot yet justify.